

# Cover letter

[Date]

Dear Editors of *Ecology and Evolution*,

We are pleased to submit the revised version of our manuscript ECE-2026-04-00956, now entitled “Snowmelt regime and dispersal limitation predict the decadal expansion of dwarf bamboo into alpine snowbed vegetation”, for consideration as a Research Article.

The manuscript addresses a practical question in alpine conservation: where, and how fast, will dwarf bamboo (*Sasa* spp.) expand into snowbed vegetation over the coming decade? Using 10 years of ground-based time-lapse imagery of a slope on Mt. Tateyama, we mapped *Sasa* at 1 m resolution in 2012 and 2021 and derived per-pixel snowmelt dates. We then separated two questions that a single suitability map conflates: where environmental conditions permit *Sasa* (a habitat suitability model), and how far existing fronts can actually reach (an establishment model fitted to the observed transitions). Establishment was most strongly associated with proximity to existing patches, and projected near-term expansion was concentrated in two snowbed communities adjoining current fronts.

We thank the Associate Editor and the three reviewers for their detailed and constructive comments. In response, we have restructured the manuscript around the two models, replaced causal language about snowmelt with associational language, added gross expansion, gross loss, and net change as distinct quantities, added a blind interpretation of paired images and an adjacency analysis to address apparent loss to dwarf pine, redesigned all figures, and expanded the Supporting Information with the classifier specification, predictor diagnostics, and sensitivity analyses. A point-by-point response accompanies this letter.

This manuscript has not been published elsewhere and is not under consideration by any other journal. All authors have approved the submission. The authors declare no conflicts of interest. [Data and code: Zenodo DOI to be inserted.]

Thank you for considering our revised manuscript.

Sincerely,

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